sound bite, worthy of a redoubtable Rajput. ‘They think I am a fossil, but I am a proud fossil!’

‘If he had stayed in the party, we could have considered him for governor or even as ambassador to the US,’ a senior BJP leader later told me. The Jaswant episode highlights that, contrary to speculation, it wasn’t Modi who was unilaterally taking decisions on ticket distribution. In a collective exercise, state leaders were given a much greater say. But there were a few seats, especially in Gujarat, where Modi had veto power. One such seat was Ahmedabad east. A seven-time MP, the silver-tongued Harin Pathak represented one of the safest BJP seats in the country. But Modi was convinced that Pathak, who was close to Advani, was part of a group in Gujarat that had tried to undermine his authority. ‘I have given my life for this party when we were nothing in Gujarat, but you know how Modi is. He can be very vindictive,’ Pathak later told me ruefully. The seat was given instead to film star Paresh Rawal, whose dialogue delivery, many said, had a striking resemblance to that of Modi.

While the BJP had a surfeit of ticket aspirants, the Congress had a very different problem—in some states like Bengal, it wasn’t even finding enough candidates to contest. ‘If you know anyone who speaks good Bengali, let us know!’ one Congress leader told me jokingly. Worse, some of its sitting MPs, including Union ministers like Manish Tewari, didn’t even want to contest. While the tickets were being decided, Tewari was admitted to hospital complaining of chest pain. The official reason he gave us was, ‘I don’t think I can stand up to the pace of an election campaign.’ While his health was a concern, Manish was also upset that the party hadn’t allowed him to contest from his preferred Chandigarh seat. With the Congress left with no allies in Tamil Nadu, finance minister Chidambaram also dropped out, pitching for his son to contest instead. ‘Mr Chidambaram isn’t sacrificing his seat—he is sacrificing his son instead,’ was the joke in the Congress headquarters.

Rahul, meanwhile, had pitched his own ‘novel’ idea to the party at its AICC session—a system of US-style primaries to select candidates in fifteen specific constituencies. ‘We must empower our grass-roots workers.